

3.1.5 Area of study 3: Traditional music

For the purpose of this specification, traditional music is defined as music that takes influences from traditional sources including folk music and reinterprets them in a contemporary style, and traditional music from traditional sources and cultures that is performed as intended by the composer.

Listening – unfamiliar music

Students must be able to listen attentively to unfamiliar music from the following styles/genres to identify and accurately describe musical elements, musical contexts and musical language:

- Blues music from 1920–1950
- Fusion music incorporating African and/or Caribbean music
- Contemporary Latin music
- Contemporary Folk music of the British Isles.

Study piece

Paul Simon *Graceland* album – the following three tracks:

- *Graceland*
- *Diamonds on the Soles of Her Shoes*
- *You Can Call Me Al*

(first teaching 2020, first assessment 2022, final assessment 2025)

Esperanza Spalding – the following three tracks:

- *I Know You Know*
- *Little Fly*
- *I Adore You*

(first taught 2024, first assessed 2026)

Musical elements

In addition to the musical elements listed for Area of study 1, students must know and understand musical elements appropriate to this Area of study.

The following table contains all the musical elements, for this area of study, that students must know and understand to answer questions in section A (Listening) and section B (Study piece). Marks will also be awarded for knowledge of other terms if relevant to this area of study in section B (Study piece) of the exam.

Element type	Element
Melody	• blue notes • pentatonic, whole tone, modal • slide/glissando/portamento, pitch bend, appoggiaturas • ostinato • riff • melody–scat • melisma • improvisation.
Tonality	• modal • pentatonic.
Structure	• strophic, verse and chorus, cyclic • call and response • popular song forms • structure–12/16 bar blues.
Sonority (Timbre)	• generic families of instruments as found in traditional/world music eg steel drums • the use of technology, synthesised and computer-generated sounds, sampling and the use of techniques such as reverb, distortion and chorus • drone • vocal techniques eg falsetto, vibrato, rap.
Texture	• a cappella • imitative • layered/layering.

Element type	Element
Tempo, metre and rhythm	• irregular, free • skank • bubble • clave (Bo Diddley type beat) • augmentation, diminution • anacrusis • hemiola • bi-rhythm, cross-rhythm, polyrhythm • shuffle beat • backbeat • syncopation • off-beat • bossa nova • samba • salsa • tango • habanera • danzón • merengue • cha-cha-cha • rumba.